

8 English Lines Developers Use in a Stand-Up When Blocked

Eight lines for the forty seconds you get in a daily stand-up, including the hard half — saying you are blocked, and asking for help with a time on it. These are not vocabulary words. They are the exact sentences a senior developer uses, in the order they use them.

The eight phrases

The same eight lines, now with the pronunciation and the reason each one works. Listen, then say each out loud.

1/8

Yesterday I finished the export job, so that one is off my list.

/ˈjɛstədəɪ aɪ ˈfɪnɪʃt ði ˈɛkspɔːt dʒɒb səʊ ðæt wʌn ɪz ɒf maɪ lɪst/

OPENING WITH WHAT MOVED

INSTEAD OF Yesterday I was working on the export job.

Why it works. Working on tells them where your time went. Finished tells them what moved. A stand-up is a list of changes, not a diary.

Yesterday I finished the export job, so that one's off my list. It went out last night.

Kahapon po natapos ko na ang export job, kaya wala na po iyon sa listahan ko.

2/8

Today I am on the retry logic, and I should have it by four.

/tə'deɪ aɪ æm ɒn ðə 'ri:traɪ 'lɒdʒɪk ænd aɪ ʃʊd hæv ɪt baɪ fɔː/

PUTTING A CLOCK ON TODAY

INSTEAD OF Today I will continue with the retry logic.

Why it works. Continue has no end in it. A time is a plan, not a promise, and the team can work around a plan. It also gives you something to say tomorrow.

Today I'm on the retry logic, and I should have it by four, unless the tests fight back.

Ngayon po nasa retry logic ako, at sa tingin ko po ay matatapos ko ito bago mag-alas-kuwatro.

3/8

I am blocked on the staging keys.

/aɪ æm blɒkt ɒn ðə 'steɪdʒɪŋ ki:z/

NAMING THE THING, NOT YOURSELF

INSTEAD OF I am a bit stuck, sorry.

Why it works. Sorry makes it your fault. A bit makes it small enough to ignore. Take both out and you have a fact the room can act on.

I'm blocked on the staging keys, so the deploy is not going out today.

Naka-block po ako sa staging keys.

4/8

This has been open since Tuesday.

/ðɪs hæz bi:n 'əʊpən sɪns 'tju:zdeɪ/

SHOWING HOW LONG IT HAS RUN

INSTEAD OF Still working on it.

Why it works. Still working on it sounds the same on day one and day three. A date puts a cost on it. Nobody can weigh a problem with no time attached.

This has been open since Tuesday, so that's three mornings now.

Naka-open pa rin po ito mula pa noong Martes.

5/8

The only thing that unblocks this is access to the staging keys.

/ði 'əʊnli θɪŋ ðæt ən'blɒks ðɪs ɪz 'æksɛs tu: ðə 'steɪdʒɪŋ ki:z/

NAMING WHAT WOULD CLEAR IT

INSTEAD OF I will keep trying.

Why it works. Say what is in the way and they know you are stopped. Say what would move it and they know what to do. Only one of those needs a reply.

The only thing that unblocks this is access to the staging keys. Nothing else is in my way.

Ang kailangan lang po para matuloy ito ay ang access sa staging keys.

6/8

Who is the right person to ask about the staging keys?

/hu: ɪz ðə raɪt 'pɜ:sən tu: ɑ:sk ə'baʊt ðə 'steɪdʒɪŋ ki:z/

ASKING FOR A NAME

INSTEAD OF Does anyone know anything about the staging keys?

Why it works. Anyone means nobody. Six people all wait for someone else to speak. Ask who, not whether, and one person answers.

Who's the right person to ask about the staging keys? Is that Sam?

Sino po ang tamang tao na dapat kong tanungin tungkol sa staging keys?

7/8

Can someone give me twenty minutes after this?

/kæn 'sʌmwʌn gɪv mi: 'twenti 'mɪnɪts 'ɑ:ftə ðɪs/

MAKING THE ASK SMALL

INSTEAD OF Let me know if anyone has time to help.

Why it works. Let me know puts the work on them. Twenty minutes is small enough to say yes to. A size and a time make help easy to give.

Can someone give me twenty minutes after this? Twenty is genuinely enough.

Puwede po ba akong bigyan ng dalawampung minuto pagkatapos nito?

8/8

If it is still blocked by two, I will come back and say so.

/ɪf ɪt ɪz stɪl blɒkt baɪ tuː aɪ wɪl kʌm bæk ænd seɪ səʊ/

BOOKING THE NEXT CHECK

INSTEAD OF I will let you know how it goes.

Why it works. You book the next check yourself, so nobody has to remember to chase you. It also stops the problem quietly becoming tomorrow's.

If it's still blocked by two, I'll come back and say so rather than let it run into tomorrow.

Kung naka-block pa rin po ito sa alas-dos, babalikan ko po ito at sasabihin ko agad.

The steps

This is the sequence. It does not change.



Done · Doing · Blocked · Ask

Four steps. Most teams stop after three, and a blocker with no ask on the end of it is only a status update. The fourth step is the one that gets you help.

Now you produce it

Write your answer first, then compare. Retrieving the phrase from a situation is what moves it into the language you can actually use under pressure. There is more than one right answer.

1. It is your turn and you finished something yesterday. Open with it.

Yesterday I finished the export job, so that one is off my list.

Working on tells them where your time went. Finished tells them what moved. A stand-up is a list of changes, not a diary.

2. You are halfway through the retry logic. Say what today looks like, and when.

Today I am on the retry logic, and I should have it by four.

Continue has no end in it. A time is a plan, not a promise, and the team can work around a plan. It also gives you something to say tomorrow.

3. You are not going to move today, and it is not for want of trying. Name the thing in the way.

I am blocked on the staging keys.

Sorry makes it your fault. A bit makes it small enough to ignore. Take both out and you have a fact the room can act on.

4. Nobody in the circle knows how long this has been open. Tell them.

This has been open since Tuesday.

Still working on it sounds the same on day one and day three. A date puts a cost on it. Nobody can weigh a problem with no time attached.

5. You have named what is in the way. Now say the one thing that would clear it.

The only thing that unblocks this is access to the staging keys.

Say what is in the way and they know you are stopped. Say what would move it and they know what to do. Only one of those needs a reply.

6. You need the staging keys and you do not know who holds them.

Who is the right person to ask about the staging keys?

Anyone means nobody. Six people all wait for someone else to speak. Ask who, not whether, and one person answers.

7. You need a real pair of eyes on this, not a vague offer of help.

Can someone give me twenty minutes after this?

Let me know puts the work on them. Twenty minutes is small enough to say yes to. A size and a time make help easy to give.

8. The stand-up is ending and you already suspect this will not be clear by lunchtime. Say what happens then.

If it is still blocked by two, I will come back and say so.

You book the next check yourself, so nobody has to remember to chase you. It also stops the problem quietly becoming tomorrow's.

Come back to this

Two situations, on the two days the research says matter. Say the phrase out loud before you look at the list again.

3/day **Day 3**

Three days ago you learned the four steps: done, doing, blocked, ask. New situation. Nothing is blocking you at all today. Say the whole update out loud in three sentences. One of the four steps has nothing to fill it. Which one, and what can you put there instead so the circle keeps expecting an ask from you?

7/day **Day 7**

One week in, and this time you are the one in the way. Somebody else's card has not moved for three mornings because they are waiting on your review. Two of the eight lines still work said in that direction. Which two, and which one do you say before they have to ask you for it?

